paid locals to serve as guides and porters, but such cash transactions meant they were essentially hiring logistical mercenaries, and, like most mercenaries, these actors were unreliable. They often dumped the jihadis' gear at the first sign of trouble, and at times turned them in to the authorities. By developing a network of its own Lashkar increased its operational capabilities and its internal security, thereby enabling it to step into the breach throughout the region when other groups' capacity to carry out attacks declined.[86] In addition, these local actors helped Lashkar to find new routes across which to launch their operatives when fencing was installed along the LoC in 2003. Bringing more Kashmiris into its ranks had also become important following Musharraf's edict in 2002 that only Kashmiri groups would wage the Kashmir jihad. Most of its fighters continued to be Pakistani, but increasing the presence of locals in support roles gave Lashkar more of a Kashmiri face and helped to promote the fiction that it was no longer a Pakistani outfit. To this end, Lashkar and two other Pakistani groups also joined the Kashmir Resistance Force and, through it, the United Jihad Council in October 2003.[87] This appears to have been done at the ISI's behest as a way to buttress their credentials as purely indigenous outfits.[88]

While Lashkar brought more Kashmir Muslims into its ranks to play non-military roles, it also increased its focus on attacking 'soft' targets in Indian-administered Kashmir. In part this owed to the improved efficacy of the Indian security forces, but it was also a way to foment communal tensions and keep India-Pakistan relations in limbo. So too was the group's involvement in terrorism directed against the Indian heartland, which increased during this decade. According to one member of the Indian security services, based on intelligence gathering and information provided by captured operatives, Lashkar leaders are believed to have met in 2002 or early 2003 and determined it was necessary to accelerate the pace of attacks inside India.[89] The Indian economy had begun to grow more quickly after 2002 and the group also increased its focus on economic targets. The terror campaign against India continued to include bombing attacks launched in concert with indigenous actors as well as fidayeen assaults, for which Lashkar dispatched its own highly trained operatives. The former were intended to bleed India through a consistent campaign of coercion, while the latter were higher-profile operations staged to draw attention.